

Dvar Torah Outline — Rabbi Shulman on the Maharal: The Purpose of Yetziat Mitzrayim and Why Hashem “Dwells” Below

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman learns a passage (פרק ס"ו) from the Maharal (אמר יהודה בן בצלאל) arguing that any great divine act must have a correspondingly great purpose. He shows how the Torah itself defines the telos of Yetziat Mitzrayim: that Hashem be our God and that His שכינה dwell among us—seen through the sequence of redemption, Aseret HaDibrot, Mishpatim, and finally the Mishkan. Rabbi Shulman then addresses the philosophical challenge: if “השמים כסאו והארץ הדום רגליו,” why would Hashem choose to dwell in the lowly physical world, and he begins explaining that the deepest קשר is specifically between the עילה (Bestower) and the עלול/מקבל (recipient).

I. A principle: every major undertaking demands a major purpose

A. The basic claim (Maharal, פרק ס"ו)

- Rabbi Shulman cites: “כאשר לכל דבר יבוקש תכלית... ולפי עניינו שלו יש לו תכלית”
 - Everything has a purpose, and its purpose matches its nature.
- If the *action* is significant, the *goal* must be significant:
 - “שאם היה הפועל פועל חשוב וגדול, ראוי שיהיה לו גם כן תכלית חשוב”
 - It is absurd for a massive enterprise to aim at something low or trivial:
 - “שאין ראוי שיהיה תכלית פחות ושפל לפועל חשוב”

B. Applying this to Hashem’s actions

- Human beings sometimes do huge projects for questionable ends (Rabbi Shulman’s example: “going to the moon”), but:
 - “וכל שכן פועל האל שכל פעולותיו בחכמה ובשכל”
- Therefore, the enormous “operation” of Yetziat Mitzrayim must have a correspondingly weighty תכלית.

II. The Torah states the purpose of Yetziat Mitzrayim explicitly (4:31)

A. The “four expressions” as purpose-language

- Rabbi Shulman points to the פסוקים describing redemption and its end-goal:
 - “וְהוֹצֵאתִי אֶתְכֶם מִתַּחַת סְבִלַת מִצְרַיִם... וְלָקַחְתִּי אֶתְכֶם לִי לְעָם וְהָיִיתִי לָכֶם לֵאלֹהִים”
(“I will take you out from under the burdens of Egypt... and I will take you to Me as a people, and I will be to you as God.”)
- The “take you to Me” and “I will be your God” are framed as the core תכלית.

B. A second פסוק: leaving Egypt in order that Hashem dwell among Israel

- Rabbi Shulman cites the formulation from the end of Parashat Tetzaveh:
 - “הַמּוֹצִיא אֶתְכֶם מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם לִשְׁכֵנִי בְּתוֹכָם”
(“[I am] the One Who took you out of the land of Egypt to dwell among them.”)
 - Conclusion:
 - “מוֹכַח שֶׁתְּחִלַּת הַיְצִיָּאָה הִיא עַל מִנַּת שִׁיְהִיָּה לָהֶם לֵאלֹהִים”
 - The יציאה is aimed at relationship: Hashem as our God, with His שכינה among us.
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III. The unfolding סדר הפרשיות: God → Torah → Mishpatim → Mishkan (6:00)

A. Redemption leads to Aseret HaDibrot: accepting Hashem as our God

- Rabbi Shulman explains the sequence:
 - First: Yetziat Mitzrayim
 - Then: Aseret HaDibrot beginning with:
 - “אֲנִכִּי ה' אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר הוֹצֵאתִיךָ מֵאֶרֶץ מִצְרַיִם”
(“I am Hashem your God Who took you out of the land of Egypt.”)
 - Followed by:
 - “לֹא יִהְיֶה לְךָ אֱלֹהִים אֲחֵרִים”
(“You shall not have other gods.”)
- Point: The first dibra embeds the purpose—Hashem’s lordship over Israel rooted in redemption.

B. Why Mishpatim comes next: law is an expression of lordship

- Rabbi Shulman: once Hashem is accepted as our God, we must accept His משפטים:
 - “כי מאחר שהוא לאלוקים להם, צריכים לקבל את משפטיו”
- Conceptual claim:
 - Every “אלוקים” (in the sense of lord/judge) has “משפט”—a rule-system.
 - “Guidance” is impossible without “judgment” (yes/no boundaries):
 - “ואין הנהגה בלא משפט... שהמשפט הוא הנהגת העם”

C. Practical halachic/moral implication: the severity of going to non-Jewish courts

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's logic:
 - Bringing a dispute to ערכאות של עובדי עבודה זרה gives “honor” to alien lordship:
 - “שמקבל עליו משפט אלוקי נכר... שכל משפט שייר לאלוקות”
- He notes there are limited exceptions in cases of necessity, but emphasizes the general prohibition as the norm.

D. The next step after Mishpatim: the Mishkan and the שכינה

- Rabbi Shulman connects the sequence to:
 - “ועשו לי מקדש ושכנתי בתוכם”
(“They shall make for Me a sanctuary, and I will dwell among them.”)
- Summation of the purpose:
 - “תכלית היציאה שיהיה להם אלוקים ולהיות שכינתו ביניהם”
 - Two goals: Hashem as our God; Hashem dwelling among us.

IV. The philosophical challenge: “Hashem is above”—why dwell below? (13:30)

A. The question from Tanach's imagery of transcendence

- Rabbi Shulman raises the problem using the verse:
 - “השמים כסאי והארץ הדם רגלי”
(“The heavens are My throne and the earth is My footstool.”)
- If Hashem's presence is “בעליונים,” why choose “תחתונים” as the place of שכינה?

B. The intuition behind the question

- Rabbi Shulman frames it as almost counter-intuitive / degrading:
 - "מעלין ולא מורידין" — "we normally elevate rather than 'bring down' —
 - Stronger formulation:
 - Why would Hashem need beings who are "עפר... רימה... ותולעה" (dust, maggots, worms)?
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V. The beginning of the answer: the deepest relationship is with the recipients below (16:00)

A. If all existence depends on שכינה בתחתונים, the question falls away

- Rabbi Shulman quotes the pivot:
 - "אם נמצא שכל דבר המציאות תלויה בשכינתו בתחתונים... מעתה הוסרה השאלה"
- Meaning: If dwelling below is essential to the entire structure of existence, it becomes the highest "purpose," not a descent.

B. The Maharal's framework: מקבל and עלול / משפיע and עילה

- Rabbi Shulman introduces the metaphysics:
 - Hashem is "עילת הכל" (the First Cause / Bestower).
 - The world is the מקבל / עלול (recipient).
 - Their "attachment" is precisely in this giver–receiver relationship:
 - "התקשרות הסיבה הראשונה בנמצאים... והנמצאים הם עלולים ממנו"

C. Why this elevates the "lower" world over the "upper" worlds

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes: this bond is not uniquely with the עליונים; rather, it is specifically with the תחתונים:
 - "אין עליך לומר שמיוחדים בזה העליונים, כי אם התחתונים"
 - The angelic/upper realms function more like intermediaries, while the recipient is the "end of the line" (Rabbi Shulman's "middleman" analogy from modern business/AI):
 - Middle layers can be "cut out," but source and recipient are definitionally necessary.
 - Therefore, the ultimate תכלית is where the relationship culminates: with the מקבל—human reality below.
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VI. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman (via the Maharal) argues that a massive divine act demands a correspondingly massive purpose.
- The Torah defines Yetziat Mitzrayim's purpose as: **Hashem becoming Israel's God** and **His dwelling among them** שכינה.
- The סדר הפרשיות reflects this: redemption → "אָנֹכִי ה'" → Mishpatim (law as lordship) → Mishkan ("ושכנתי בתוכם").
- The challenge "why dwell below?" is answered by reframing reality as a giver–receiver system: the deepest קשר is with the מקבלים, where the divine purpose is realized (תחתונים).